2025 Council Climate Action Scorecards

Climate Emergency UK assessed all UK councils on the actions they've taken towards net zero between January 2020 and October 2024.

Find out more at
Action Scorecards · England

CLIMATE EMERGENCY UK

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We've summarised the key findings from across the district, county and single tier authorities in England to provide an overview of these English councils' results in the 2025 Council Climate Action Scorecards.

Whilst the scores vary across England, it is noticeable that, of the lowest scoring councils in the UK, most are in England, with **12 English councils scoring less than 20%.** Since Northern Ireland adopted the Climate Change (Reporting Bodies) Regulations in 2024, England is now the only nation in the UK where there is still no statutory duty for councils to act on climate.

2025 average score and 2023 comparison[1]

by council type

42% Single Tier ▲ 7

36% District councils ▲ 7

40% County councils ▲ 5

51% Mayoral Authority ▲ 1

37% Wales ▲ 7

39% Scotland ▲ 5

24% Northern Ireland ▲ 3

LEADING THE WAY

90% ▲ 9 versus 2023
of English councils[2] have a Climate Action Plan with SMART targets[3]

90% ▲ 5 versus 2023
of English councils have a named climate Portfolio Holder[4]

89% ▲ 10 versus 2023
of English local authorities[5] have reduced mowing or created wildflower habitat in their area[6]

ROOM FOR IMPROVEMENT

64% ▲ 4 versus 2023
of English planning authorities have set the highest water efficiency standards for new builds[7]

67% ▲ 5 versus 2023
of English transport authorities have low-emission buses used on routes[8]

70% ▲ 8 versus 2023
of English councils produced an annual Climate Action Plan update report[9]

FALLING BEHIND

13% ▲ 6 versus 2023
have adopted a detailed decision making process that puts the climate crisis at the heart of all council decisions[10]

22% ▲ 5 versus 2023
of English planning authorities have set net zero standards for building new housing[11]

5 ▼ 2 councils versus 2023
English local authorities recycle more than 60% of their waste and no councils recycle more than 70%[12]

(1) Nation comparison available at: https://councilclimatescorecards.uk/nations/
Check the Scorecards results for English Local Authorities at: https://councilclimatescorecards.uk/nations/england/
(2) English councils include all 327 English local and mayoral authorities assessed in the 2025 Council Climate Action Scorecards
(3) Collaboration & Engagement · Question 2a - Has the council published a Climate Action Plan with SMART targets? and Collaboration & Engagement (Mayoral Authorities) Question 1a Has the mayoral authority published a climate action plan with SMART targets?
(4) Governance & Finance · Question 7 - Does the council have a Cabinet member or Portfolio Holder that has climate change explicitly in their remit? and Governance & Finance (Mayoral Authorities) · Question 8 - Does the mayoral authority have a Cabinet member or Portfolio Holder that has climate change explicitly in their remit?
(5) English local authorities excludes the 9 mayoral authorities
(6) Biodiversity · Question 3 - Has the council committed to mowing their green spaces less for wildlife?
(7) Planning authorities include District and Single Tier councils.
Planning & Land Use · Question 5 - Does the council require a higher level of water efficiency for all new homes? The highest water efficiency standards are 110 litres of water per person per day in England and Wales, with Scotland using a per appliance metric.
(8) Transport authorities include County, Single Tier and Mayoral Authorities.
Transport · Question 8a - Are there any low emission buses used within the council's area? and Transport · (Mayoral Authorities) Question 4c Is the mayoral authority transitioning the bus fleet in their area to be zero-emission?
(9) Collaboration & Engagement · Question 2b - Has the council published an up to date and easy-to-read annual report on their Climate Action Plan? and Collaboration & Engagement (Mayoral Authorities) Question 1b - Has the mayoral authority published an up to date and easy-to-read annual report on their Climate Action Plan?
(10) Second tier criteria - Governance & Finance · Question 5 - Has the council adopted a new governance or decision making process to put tackling the climate emergency at the heart of every council decision made? and Governance & Finance ·(Mayoral Authorities) Question 6 Has the mayoral authority adopted a new governance or decision making process to put tackling the climate emergency at the heart of every council decision made?
(11) Planning authorities include District and Single Tier councils.
Planning & Land Use · Question 3c - Does the council set a requirement that all new homes to be built must be operationally (regulated) net zero? A net zero standard is defined as when the regulated operational emissions, which are the emissions from the use of the building, are zero or negative. See UKGBC for more detail.
(12) Waste Reduction & Food · Question 8 - How high is the councils' area wide annual recycling rate?